# Item Writing Guidelines

Examinations Office — standing guidance for subject leads. Revision 7, September 2026.

## 1. Before you write

Agree the blueprint first. A blueprint states how many items each topic receives and at which cognitive level. Writing items before the blueprint exists produces a bank that is dense where writing was easy and empty where it was not.

Every item must trace to a syllabus outcome. An item that traces to nothing is unmarkable in a challenge, because there is no agreed standard to measure the candidate's answer against.

## 2. While you write

Write the correct answer first, then the distractors. Writing distractors first produces items where the correct option is the one that reads most carefully.

Each distractor should correspond to a named misconception. Record the misconception alongside the item. When the item is reviewed in two years, that note is the only thing that explains why the distractor is there.

Keep numeric options in order. A candidate scanning an unordered numeric list is doing arithmetic on the layout.

## 3. Review

Two reviewers, one of whom did not write the item. The writer cannot see their own ambiguity; that is what makes it ambiguity rather than a mistake.

Review for accessibility at the same time. An item that depends on colour, on a figure with no alternative text, or on a cultural reference is measuring something other than the outcome.

## 4. After the sitting

Compute facility and discrimination for every item. Retire items with negative discrimination immediately: a negative value means stronger candidates chose a distractor, which is evidence the key is wrong or the stem is misleading.

Record the exposure count. Items are a depleting resource and a bank with no exposure tracking has no idea which of its items are already in circulation.